



The Caribbean

THIS REGION CONSISTS of thousands of islands stretching from Cuba in the west to Trinidad and Tobago in the southeast. European colonists wanted control of the islands in the 1500s, but the diseases they brought wiped out most of the local Carib and Arawak peoples. African slaves, imported to work on plantations, replaced local peoples and today most of the population are descended from those Africans. English, Spanish, and French are spoken in different countries, depending on which European power claimed the territory. Tourism and agriculture are major sources of employment.



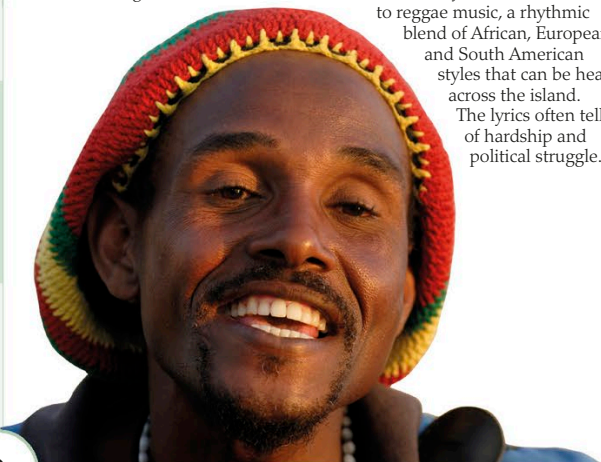
CUBA
Cuba is the largest island and the only communist country in the region. It was supported by the communist superpower, the USSR, until the USSR collapsed in 1991, at which time many Cubans suffered great economic hardship. The Cuban government invested its money in improving social services. The people benefit from a good health service and a high literacy rate. Children who complete pre-university education are awarded the *Bachillerato*.



Cuba specializes in making top-quality cigars.

JAMAICA
The Rastafarian religion began in Kingston, Jamaica, in the 1930s. Followers worship Haile Selassie, the former emperor of Ethiopia (Ras Tafari), and believe that God will lead black people back to Ethiopia, the Promised Land. Jamaica is also home to reggae music, a rhythmic blend of African, European, and South American styles that can be heard across the island. The lyrics often tell of hardship and political struggle.

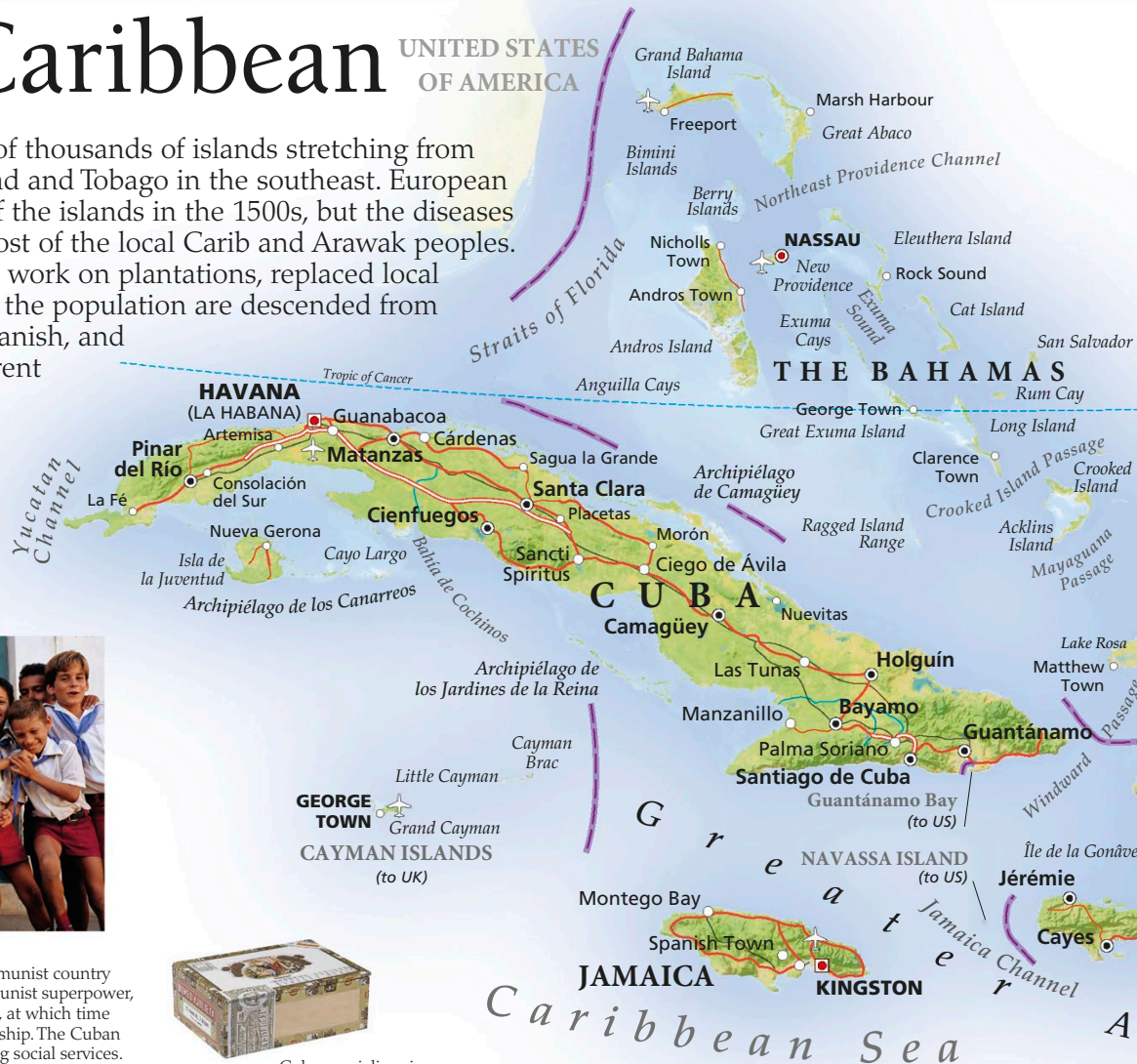
Rastafarian, whose religion forbids him from cutting his hair



The most densely populated country in the Caribbean is Barbados.

CARIBBEAN CROPS

The semi-tropical climate here creates ideal conditions for many crops, especially sugar. The growing and processing of sugar is an important industry in Cuba, Jamaica, and many of the Lesser Antilles, providing jobs and income for the region. Fermented cane sugar is used to make rum and is a major export.



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